

The University of Texas at El Paso
Department of Sociology and Anthropology

COURSE INFORMATION

ANTH1302-007 World Cultures

CRN: 11420

Term: Fall 2025

Delivery Method: Online course in Blackboard

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Alison Lee, PhD

Written Communication: Please contact me through the Blackboard course using the message function, or by email: aelee5@utep.edu I will respond within 24-48 hours Monday through Friday.

Office Hours:

- Virtual: Thursdays from 6pm to 8pm by appointment only. Please make an appointment by email or Blackboard. I will send you a videoconferencing link when we confirm the appointment.

Course Information: What this class is about and what we will do

COURSE DESCRIPTION

In this course we explore the diversity of beliefs and behaviors of cultures in different parts of the world. The study of cultural diversity allows us to understand the richness of human experience. In anthropology, our understanding of human beings is not only based on the industrialized cultures of the world. Rather, we are interested in having a broad view of the social organization and cultural worlds of other groups, from foragers to humans who inhabit capitalist economies. Furthermore, studying other sociocultural groups helps us better understand ourselves.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- Identify the principal domains of Cultural Anthropology and the methodologies that define ethnographic practice.
- Critically examine anthropological perspectives on the concepts of culture and society, along with the challenges posed by cultural relativism.
- Compare different forms of economic, social and political organization as well as kinship.
- Analyze forms of social differentiation (class, gender, ethnicity, etc.) and their role in shaping power relations.

EDGE ADVANTAGES

This course is designed to equip students with essential Edge Advantages that contribute to their professional and personal development. Through the completion of course requirements and assignments, students will develop the following Edge Advantages:

	Problem-Solving	Assignments will challenge students to identify and address complex issues using innovative and analytical approaches.
	Communication	Class discussions and written assignments will improve students' skills in articulating ideas clearly and persuasively in both oral and written forms.
	Confidence	By actively participating and successfully completing assignments, students will build self-assurance in their abilities to tackle academic and real-world challenges.
	Critical Thinking	The course's emphasis on analysis and synthesis of information will strengthen students' abilities to think critically and make informed decisions.

REQUIRED MATERIALS

Miller, Barbara D. *Cultural Anthropology*, 8th edition ISBN: 9780137498727

<https://pearson.com/en-us/pearsonplus/p/9780137498727>

There will be other short articles available from the UTEP library assigned throughout the course available in Blackboard. The link to these articles will be in Blackboard.

ASSIGNMENTS AND GRADING

Assignments for this course are assessed according to rubrics. You can find these rubrics by clicking on the appropriate assignment link in Blackboard and choosing to "View Rubric" from the button beneath the Points Possible for the assignment.

Grade Distribution:

100-90 = A 89-80 = B 79-70 = C 69-60 = D 59 and Below = F

- o 60 points: 4 Exams (15 points each)
- o 40 points: 8 Class activities/discussion boards (5 points each)

Exams: Exams will test your knowledge of basic concepts of the course as well as how these concepts are applied to specific ethnographic examples discussed in class and in the readings.

Class activities/discussion boards: Throughout the course, you will be expected to complete activities and/or participate in discussion boards to help you understand the class material.

TECHNOLOGY REQUIREMENTS

Course content is delivered via the Internet through the Blackboard learning management system. Ensure your UTEP e-mail account is working and that you have access to the Web and a stable web browser. Google Chrome and Mozilla Firefox are the best browsers for Blackboard; other browsers may cause complications. When having technical difficulties, update your browser, clear your cache, or try switching to another browser.

You will need to have access to a computer/laptop, scanner, a webcam, and a microphone. You will need to download or update the following software: Microsoft Office, Adobe Acrobat Reader, Windows Media Player, QuickTime, and Java. Check that your computer hardware and software are up-to-date and able to access all parts of the course.

If you do not have a word-processing software, you can download Word and other Microsoft Office programs (including Excel, PowerPoint, Outlook and more) for free via UTEP's Microsoft Office Portal. Click the following link for more information about [Microsoft Office 365](#) and follow the instructions.

IMPORTANT: If you encounter technical difficulties beyond your scope of troubleshooting, please contact the UTEP [Technology Support](#) as they are trained specifically in assisting with technological needs of students. Please do not contact me for this type of assistance. The Help Desk is much better equipped than I am to assist you!

Course Communication: How we will stay in contact with each other

Because this is an online class, we won't see each other in the ways you may be accustomed to: during class time, small group meetings, and office hours. However, there are a number of ways we can keep the communication channels open:

- **Office Hours:** We will not be able to meet on campus, but I will still have office hours for your questions and comments about the course. My office hours are Thursdays from 6pm to 8pm by appointment only. Please make an appointment by email or Blackboard. I will send you a videoconferencing link when we confirm the appointment.
- **Email:** UTEP e-mail is the best way to contact me. I will make every attempt to respond to your e-mail within 24-48 hours of receipt, Monday through Friday. When e-mailing me, be sure to email from your UTEP student account and please put the course number in the subject line. In the body of your e-mail, clearly state your question. At the end of your e-mail, be sure to put your first and last name, and your university identification number.
- **Discussion Board:** If you have a question that you believe other students may also have, please post it in the Help Board of the discussion boards inside of Blackboard. Please respond to other students' questions if you have a helpful response.
- **Announcements:** Check the Blackboard announcements frequently for any updates, deadlines, or other important messages.

NETIQUETTE

As we know, sometimes communication online can be challenging. It's possible to miscommunicate what we mean or to misunderstand what our classmates mean given the lack of body language and immediate feedback. Therefore, please keep these netiquette (network etiquette) guidelines in mind. Failure to observe them may result in disciplinary action.

- o Always consider audience. This is a college-level course; therefore, all communication should reflect polite consideration of other's ideas.
- o Respect and courtesy must be provided to classmates and to the instructor at all times. No harassment or inappropriate postings will be tolerated.
- o When reacting to someone else's message, address the ideas, not the person. Post only what anyone would comfortably state in a face-to-face situation.
- o Blackboard is not a public internet venue; all postings to it should be considered private and confidential. Whatever is posted on in these online spaces is intended for classmates and professor only. Please do not copy documents and paste them to a publicly accessible website, blog, or other space.

Course Policies: What do you need to do to be successful in the course

ATTENDANCE AND PARTICIPATION

Attendance in the course is determined by participation in the learning activities of the course. Your participation in the course is important not only for your learning and success but also to create a community of learners. Participation is determined by completion of the following activities:

- o Reading/Viewing all course materials to ensure understanding of assignment requirements
- o Participating in engaging discussion with your peers on the discussion boards (grading rubric provided in the "grading information" area of each forum)
- o Other activities as indicated in the weekly modules

Because these activities are designed to contribute to your learning each week, they cannot be made up after their due date has passed.

COURSE DROP POLICY

I will not drop you from the course. However, if you feel that you are unable to complete the course successfully, please let me know and then contact the [Registration and Records Office](#) to initiate the drop process. If you do not, you are at risk of receiving an "F" for the course.

DEADLINES AND LATE WORK

Deadlines for exams, class activities and discussion boards will be posted in Blackboard.

Because these activities are designed to contribute to your learning each week, they

cannot be made up after their due date has passed. No late work will be accepted if the reason is not considered excusable.

MAKE-UP WORK

Make-up work will be given *only* in the case of a *documented* emergency. Note that make-up work may be in a different format than the original work, may require more intensive preparation, and may be graded with penalty points. If you miss an assignment and the reason is not considered excusable, you will receive a zero. It is therefore important to reach out to me—in advance if at all possible—and explain with proper documentation why you missed a given course requirement. Once a deadline has been established for make-up work, no further extensions or exceptions will be granted.

ALTERNATIVE MEANS OF SUBMITTING WORK IN CASE OF TECHNICAL ISSUES

I strongly suggest that you submit your work with plenty of time to spare in the event that you have a technical issue with the course website, network, and/or your computer. I also suggest you save all your work (answers to discussion points, quizzes, exams, and essays) in a separate Word document as a back-up. This way, you will have evidence that you completed the work and will not lose credit. If you are experiencing difficulties submitting your work through the course website, please contact the UTEP Help Desk. You can email me your back-up document as a last resort.

INCOMPLETE GRADE POLICY

Incomplete grades may be requested only in exceptional circumstances after you have completed at least half of the course requirements. Talk to me immediately if you believe an incomplete is warranted. If granted, we will establish a contract of work to be completed with deadlines.

ACCOMMODATIONS POLICY

The University is committed to providing reasonable accommodations to students with documented disabilities. Students who become pregnant may also request reasonable accommodations, in accordance with state and federal laws and regulations and University policy. Accommodations that constitute undue hardship are not reasonable. To make a request, please register with the UTEP Center for Accommodations and Support Services (CASS). Contact CASS at 915-747-5148, email them at cass@utep.edu, or apply for accommodations online via the CASS portal.

SCHOLASTIC INTEGRITY

Academic dishonesty is prohibited and is considered a violation of the UTEP Handbook of Operating Procedures. It includes, but is not limited to, cheating, plagiarism, and collusion. Cheating may involve copying from or providing information to another student, possessing unauthorized materials during a test, or falsifying research data on laboratory reports. Plagiarism occurs when someone intentionally or knowingly represents the words or ideas of another as one's own. Collusion involves collaborating with another person to commit any academically dishonest act. Any act of academic dishonesty attempted by a UTEP student is unacceptable and will not be tolerated. All suspected violations of academic integrity at The University of Texas at El Paso must be reported to the [Office of Community Standards](#) for possible disciplinary action. To learn more, please visit [HOOP: Student Conduct and Discipline](#).

AI prohibited

Use of AI technologies or automated tools, particularly generative AI such as ChatGPT or DALL-E, is **not allowed** for assignments in this class. Each student is expected to use critical and creative thinking skills to complete tasks and not rely on computer-generated ideas. Any direct use of AI-generated materials submitted as your own work will be treated as plagiarism and reported to the [Office of Community Standards](#).

PLAGIARISM DETECTING SOFTWARE

Some of your course work and assessments may be submitted to SafeAssign, a plagiarism detecting software. SafeAssign is used to review assignment submissions for originality and will help you learn how to properly attribute sources rather than paraphrase.

COPYRIGHT STATEMENT FOR COURSE MATERIALS

All materials used in this course are protected by copyright law. The course materials are only for the use of students currently enrolled in this course and only for the purpose of this course. They may not be further disseminated.

***COURSE RESOURCES:** Where you can go for assistance

UTEP provides a variety of student services and support. Please refer to the QR code below for a listing of campus resources or visit

https://www.utep.edu/advising/student_resources/student-success-resource-hub.html.



COURSE SCHEDULE

Week	Readings	Topics
Week 1 25 – 29 August	Miller 1 [This means you are to read the first chapter of the textbook: Miller, Barbara: <i>Cultural Anthropology, Chapter 1: Anthropology and the Study of Culture</i>]	Introduction to Cultural Anthropology
Week 2 1 – 5 September	Miller 2 (The Evolution of Humanity and Culture) Minor: “Body Ritual Among the Nacirema” (This article will be available in Blackboard) Discussion Board	Ethnocentrism; Cultural Relativism
Week 3 8 – 12 September	Miller 3 (Researching Culture) Class Activity	Ethnography: Fieldwork in Anthropology
Week 4 15 – 19 September	Introduction to <i>Liquidated: an ethnography of Wall Street</i> . (The link to this reading will be available in Blackboard) First Exam	Ethnography: Fieldwork in Anthropology
Week 5 22 – 26 September	Selections: The Dawn of Everything (The link to this reading will be available in Blackboard)	The Indigenous critique
Week 6 29 September – 3 October	Selections: The Dawn of Everything (The link to this reading will be available in Blackboard)	Politics in the Pleistocene; Schismogenesis

	Discussion Board	
Week 7 6 – 10 October	Selections: The Dawn of Everything (The link to this reading will be available in Blackboard) Class Activity	Schismogenesis, con't
Week 8 13 – 17 October	Miller 5 (Consumption and Exchange) Second Exam	Exchange
Week 9 20 – 24 October	Miller 6 (Reproduction and Human Development)	Gender, reproduction and human development
Week 10 27 – 31 October	Miller 7 (Disease, Illness and Healing) Discussion Board	Medical Anthropology
Week 11 3 – 7 November	Miller 8 (Kinship and Domestic Life) Class Activity	Kinship
Week 12 10 – 14 November	Miller 9 (Social Groups and Social Stratification) Miller 10 (Power, Politics and Social Order) Third Exam	Ethnicity and Class
Week 13 17 – 21 November	Miller 11 (Communication)	Language and Communication
Week 14 24 – 26 November	Miller 12 (Religion) Discussion Board	Religion and the supernatural
Week 15 1- 5 December	Miller 14 (People on the Move) Class Activity	Human Mobility
8 – 12 December Final Exam Week	Final Exam	